Mission Briefing: Mission 4 – Psychic Nightmare

The Beacons Drink: The Third Crystal on Tlatec

The second shard did not stay buried. On the wreckage fields of Xolkan the dig ended in fire and stolen ground. Derelict demolition charges tore the trenches. Old teleporter-gates swallowed men and machines alike. When the smoke cleared, warlord Chudgore's Cult of Excessive Violence dragged the waking crystal from the field. The warbands that had marked the pits were too broken to pursue. Two Voidcrown shards now ride in hostile hands — one taken in the dark of Ontranis, one torn from Xolkan. The Voidsun heard both.

The third answered on Tlatec. It is the last of the Voidcrown crystals. Whoever carries it off this world holds the final key.

Tlatec is the cursed hinge of the outer worlds: storm-racked isles and black water, where the Frog-Mages once caged the system's psychic tempests and hid the heart of the Voidcrown. Long before the raids they raised beacons across those isles to drink the storms and keep the crown asleep. Travel here was a death sentence. Now the resonance of the stolen shards has torn the last crystal from its sleep beneath the waves. As it woke, the beacons fired. They no longer gather power for sleeping mages. They pour it into anyone fool enough to stand in their light.

Four beacons burn on the fighting ground. A caster who closes within their radius may draw a working from the crystal itself — one gift, once a round, unpaid. The gift is not clean. Reach wrong and the pylon bites the mind that touched it. Worse, the crystal does not hold a steady note. Each round the wake shifts, and the isles answer with a different cruelty. A squad may turn on itself. A spell that should have been clean burns the hand that shaped it. Wounds open wider than the blow that made them. Those who freeze are taken by the light. Courage fails without warning. The beacons choose. No commander chooses for them.

There is no ground worth holding for its own sake. The purpose is the crystal. Break the rival host. Kill their casters before they drink the beacons dry. Every successful casting is a mark the shard will remember, and only the warband that still stands when the light fades will leave Tlatec with the third and final key. Profit, vengeance, forbidden knowledge, or the need to deny the crown: the reasons differ. The crystal does not.

The storms are no longer watching from orbit. They are in the working.